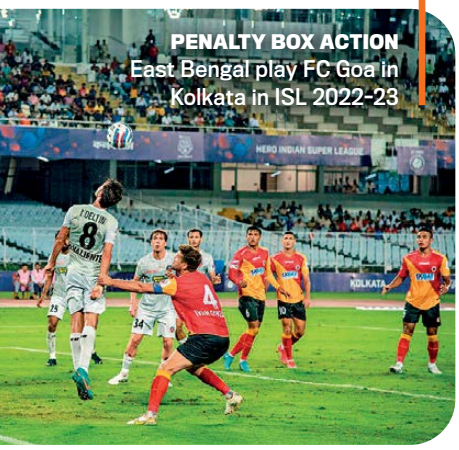


PENALTY BOX ACTION
East Bengal play FC Goa in Kolkata in ISL 2022-23

up the next day and started preparing for the ISL. The past doesn't matter and you are as good as the next game you play. So we need to put our heads down and work harder because now there are expectations, and it's not easy to live up to them," says Mandar Tamhane, chief executive officer at NorthEast United.

Besides the recent Durand Cup winners, all eyes will be on defending champions Mohun Bagan and Mumbai City FC, who stirred up an intriguing rivalry through all of last season. While Bagan pipped the Mumbai side by a solitary point to win the league crown, Mumbai City came storming back to beat them in the playoff final and lift the ISL Cup. And their campaign gets off to a rousing start as they face off in the opening fixture in Kolkata.

"We are in it to win it and that's the realistic goal for the season. The ISL is getting better. There are eight teams in contention currently that have very good signings and coaches, so it's going to be an interesting season. And for us, we'll know where we stand after the very first match," says Mumbai City head coach, Petr Kratky.

On their heels last season were FC Goa, whose coach, Manolo Marquez, will now have his hands full after being handed the reins of the Indian national team as well. It's just a matter of time before "conflict of interest" and "Indian football" are spoken of in the same breath, but that's for another time.

The big rivalry from the Kolkata maidans will now get primetime footage in the 13-team league after Mohammedan SC earned promotion from the I-League to play their maiden ISL. Alongside East Bengal, they'll surely look to dent Bagan's hopes of making it a league double.

"Derbies are special, and the Kolkata Derby is no different. You want to see your supporters happy after the match, so it demands more focus from the players during these fixtures. I want to see Kolkata draped in Mohammedan's black-and-white colours at the end of these matches," says head coach Andrey Chernyshov. ■

–Shail Desai



PTI

Along with East Bengal, Mohammedan SC in their maiden ISL will offer stiff competition to Mohun Bagan

SPORTS

On a Wing and a Bicycle

Neha Tikam recently set the record for the fastest time by a female cyclist on the Manali-Leh highway

long-distance road cycling event) between 200-300 km. She arrived in Leh three weeks before the attempt and put in around 770 km of training distance. But the initial 12 hours had been taxing. As she tucked into a hot meal at Debring, around 130 km from the starting point, she knew it would be a long night ahead. "The conditions were freezing, the temperature close to zero. When I had started, the sun was out and there were bright blue skies. Then again, I was quite aware how quickly things can change in the mountains," she says.

Tikam started tentatively, but she was clear that there was no turning around. She endured rough weather and bad roads to get to Sarchu. After pulling off a long climb to Baralacha La, she breathed easy, knowing the demanding sections were behind her. At the Atal Tunnel, she was informed that she could go no further since the road ahead was blocked. "We had to seek permission from the authorities to continue. And once on the other side, I had to hike and bike across the landslide sections in a downpour to continue making progress. There was just so much packed in this one ride that I was glad to just get to the finish and in good shape," Tikam says. ■

–Shail Desai